

Synthetic Arguments

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Collective Action

- Ziblatt 2017: can the elites solve a collective action problem in facilitating a transition to a coherent conservative political movement?
- Stigler & Becker 1990: norms can support otherwise-irrational behavior particularly because gathering the information to deviate to a new behavior away from the norm is costly
- Taylor 1990: definition satisfied when “rational individual action can lead to a strictly Pareto-inferior outcome.” Solutions can be internal (no changing of structure) or external (changing of structure)
 - Potential external solutions: political entrepreneur as coordination, stronger property rights to emphasize individualism and internalize utilities, and norms – *when there is sufficient consequence to deviating from them*
- Coleman 1990: norms emerge as outcomes / solutions from repeated PD problems
- Miller 1990: norms of cooperation solve collective action problems, but must be supported and maintained, preferably through behavioral influence and cultural adaptation rather than institutional systems
- Hardin 1990: Perverse logic of state construction: if we construct the state to enforce collective action solutions, then we must overcome the collective action problem of constructing the state itself

Development of Democracy

- Democracy as *contestation*: there exists broad inclusion and a legitimate opposition with a legitimate chance of gaining power
 - Dahl 1972: Democratization and development of the opposition are separate. Two dimensions: public contestation within politics, and the right to participate within politics. High contestation and high inclusiveness leads to polyarchy; other combinations are lesser
 - Double-transition rule: a nation is considered a developed democracy when rule transitions $A \rightarrow B \rightarrow A$
 - Dahl 1972: in the absence of any conflict, it is difficult to retain legitimate competition
- Expansion of the franchise:
 - Acemoglu & Robinson 2000 – the west extended the franchise as a credible commitment mechanism to “buy off” commoners
 - North & Weingast 1989 – expansion of property rights in 18th century England as a means of commitment against exploitation and to secure public investment

/ credit

- Dahl 1972: three paths to polyarchy, (1) liberalization before inclusiveness, (2) inclusiveness before liberalization, (3) sudden shock (often unstable). Central question: do you make a hegemonic democracy first, or do you expand inclusion but retain authoritarianism under that broader franchise? Less common on the second one
- Expansion of the franchise – intentionally or unintentionally – requires additional institutional development:
 - Dahl 1972: Candidates and parties change as the franchise expands, in an effort to better achieve their electoral goals. Often results in new parties or party change (see Muller 1997 for a more comprehensive discussion of parties changing)
 - Huntington 1968: without sufficient political development to keep up with economic development – which itself will bring greater inclusivity – we should expect discontent and instability
 - Ziblatt 2017: If this development does not allow for conservative parties to be meaningfully included in government, then the transition to democracy is likely to be unstable and short-term
- Levy 2006 – transition of the goals of the democratic state away from market-steering to market-supporting
 - Iversen & Soskice 2019: capitalism has fueled democracy, and democracy has further consolidated because of the impacts of globalization and modern development

Historical Prerequisites for Democracy

- How agrarian classes developed:
 - Dahl 1972: Farming societies differentiated into peasantry (hegemony) or free farmers (polyarchy)
- Ziblatt 2017: whether or not the elites were able to organize into a coherent political party/structure that was meaningfully involved in the democratic process, such that their interests could still be represented to some extent
- Huntington 1968 “Green uprising”: alliance of some sectors of rural and urban populations (see: workers/labour) that overcomes tensions between urbanites and rural elites and allows for stability
 - Also Huntington: “A society is vulnerable to revolution only when the opposition of the middle class to the political system coincides with the opposition of the peasants. Once the middle class becomes conservative, rural rebellion is still possible, but revolution is not.”

Nation-building & Nationality

- Four primary factors in whether an individual adopts new political beliefs: exposure, prestige, consistency w/ beliefs, consistency w/ experience **CITE**
- Cross-cutting cleavages:
 - threaten polyarchy (Dahl 1972)
- Kalyvas 2006. Nationality less influential to the outcomes of violence in civil war than would be otherwise believed, particularly given the often abstract construction of identity cleavages during war (tie to Anderson 1983?).
- Lipset & Rokkan 1967: in order for a cleavage to become politically consequential, it must have (1) empirical basis, (2) normative element, and (3) organizational expression
 - Cleavages can be reinforcing (creating more distinct but severe polarization) or cross-cutting (creating party fragmentation and cross-pressurization)

Regime Transitions

- Ziblatt 2017: enduring stability of a democratic transition requires an organized conservative movement such that the elites are not existentially threatened
- Huntington 1968: regime transition as a byproduct of institutional development (that is, the type of regime changes)
- Huntington 1968 on Modernization: replacement of esoteric authority with legitimate justifications; rise of new goals and institutions to fulfill those goals; expansion of political participation
- Levy 2006 – a little bit of a different lens, but change in the focus of democratic regimes
- Weber: tripartite authority – charismatic, traditional, and rational-legal. Huntington suggests that with modernization comes a transition away from traditional authority, and claims that the transition is to rational-legal – but, couldn't it be the case that this transition is to charismatic as well? (i.e., Napoleon)

Backsliding/Populism

- Ziblatt 2017: the rise of populist movements is antithetical to the democratic need for an organized conservative movement and can subsequently lead to instability or backsliding
- Could use Huber & Shipan 2002 to talk briefly about regulatory / bureaucratic capture, although it is more of an example of how to *avoid* these outcomes via institutional design

International Influences

- Dahl 1972: Foreign influences can directly impose institutions, affect beliefs, or affect decision sets
- Gourevitch 1978: foreign politics have significant impacts on domestic structures BEYOND just the invasion effect

Party Politics

- Parties develop as coordination mechanisms to facilitate generally-common individual behaviors into tangible political action
- Cox 1997: The number of relevant parties or candidates we should expect is a function of both the number of relevant cleavages seeking representation and the permissiveness of electoral institutions to allow for such representation. Should expect $M + 1$ relevant competitors where M is district magnitude / number of seats available; Duverger is just this with $M = 1$
 - See Posner 2004 for why some cleavages are politically salient but others are not
 - See Fearon & Laitin 2003 for why some cleavages result in violence/instability but others do not
- Lipset & Rokkan 1967: contemporary parties result from cleavages in the national revolution and industrial revolution; largely frozen in target identity groups since then
- Lipset & Rokkan 1967: for a movement to become a party, it must cross (1) legitimization, (2) incorporation, (3) representation, and (4) a plausible chance of achieving a position in government

Methodological Reasoning

- Single biggest example of endogeneity probably comes down to whether development drives democracy or democracy drives development. A series of different arguments:
 - Democracy drives economic development:
 - * North & Weingast 1989: protection of property rights leads to investment of capital which in turn leads to economic development
 - * North 1990: it is the development of meaningful political institutions which leads to economic growth (more generally)
 - Economic development drives democracy:
 - * Ziblatt 2017 – the development of a well-organized conservative elite (alongside the middle class, or some portion therein) is crucial to allowing a democratic system to both emerge and be sustained

- * Moore 1966
- * Ostrom 1990: institutions emerge to solve CPR problems which arise from resource endowments or economic development
- Both
 - * Iversen & Soskice 2019: democracy drives capitalistic tendencies, and capitalistic features drive democracy (particularly when the median voter has a vested interest in the development of national capital)
 - * Putnam 1993: social capital drives democratic development – this development leads to better economic development, but social capital itself may be stronger in settings where economic wellbeing is present or improving
- Neither
 - * Huntington 1968: political development does not inherently occur when economic development occurs; rather, it must be imposed or risk significant instability. (That being said, this development can be an influence on the decision to impose such institutions.)

Empirical Logic & Evaluation

- Huber & Shipman 2002: use the institutional environment as a separate variable rather than a fixed component of situational context
- Elster 1990: Theories can fail to explain through either indeterminacy and inadequacy, the second being more troubling. It is not inherently discrediting for a theory to be indeterminate, however – it may be useful to exclude certain possibilities or mechanisms

Rationality & Limits

General thoughts:

- Kalyvas 2006 as an example of applied rationality to collective identities, though possible that this is an overextension of rational choice as it requires collapsing humanistic tendencies into measurable incentives. (However, could also see it as a monumental success within this effort to apply rationality to identity)
- Cook & Levi 1990: “The descriptive approach to rational choice focuses on the patterns of observable choices” – *then* makes the assumption that these choices are rooted in rationality
- Elster 1990: even if rational choice theory does not always produce the best or most accurate answer, equilibria conclusions may help guide our search for particular answers, behaviors, or mechanisms. However, its tendency to produce multiple equilibria with relative difficulty deciding between them is less than ideal

- “Rational choice theory is first and foremost normative. It tells us what we ought to do in order to achieve our aims as well as possible.”
- Broader commentary outside of Elster – perhaps the most useful application of RCT is comparative statics, that even if we cannot predict an outcome, we can reasonably predict how an outcome might change as some input changes
- Elster 1990: Three optimization operations of rational choice. Optimal actions given beliefs, optimal beliefs given information, optimal information given desires/priors
- Elster 1990: “Rationality is presupposed by any competing theory of motivation, whereas rationality itself does not presuppose anything else. On grounds of parsimony, therefore, we should begin by assuming nothing but rationality.”
- Social norms can be seemingly irrational, but it is perhaps following them which produces rationality
- Tversky & Kahneman 1990: rational predictions diverge prohibitively from behavioral outcomes; largely a result of psychological violations of VNM assumptions. Perhaps the largest one is framing, whereby “invariance” is violated – the same piece of information presented two different ways tends to yield vastly different behavioral outcomes
- Machina 1990: behavior seems to be inconsistent with rational expectations under uncertainty, but provides some structural relief to Tversky & Kahneman and suggests that “generalized expected utility” may still be a functional contribution
- Stigler & Becker 1990: norms provide a stickiness to the status quo; deviating from norms induces an informational cost. (Could be a good jump to Romer/Rosenthal if needed)
- Stinchcombe 1990: “What we want of our institutions of reason is a proper balance between efficient formal approximations that can have a reliable social effect, and substantive good sense to know their limits and to improve them.”
- Miller 1990: control by means of effective incentive design is contradictory and disproven by social choice; instead, personalistic leadership (i.e., inspiration, interpersonal encouragement) is an optimal approach. Directly tied to Weber 1968’s discussion of charismatic leadership, and directly opposed to the Northian view of institutional supremacy

Specific examples:

- Cox 1997: much of electoral politics happens outside of equilibrium
- Lijphart 1999: (my critique) characterizes a great deal of out-of-equilibrium behavior rather than ultimately proved short lived and ineffective

Positive Theory

- Positivism: use of rational logic and empirical reasoning to come to conclusions. Every piece of information is either from first principles or can be justified logically/empirically
- Weber as an antipositivist: move instead towards evaluating broader social phenomena and interactions as being highly humanistic (this is also interpretism)
- See Geertz 1973 “Thick Description” for a modern interpretation of interpretivism

Personal note on this – good interpretivist theory should essentially be positive as well, at least insofar as it can be reflected by formal incentive modeling. If we cannot come up with a rational explanation *based on the results of interpretivist reasoning*, then the answer is at the very least incomplete. Yet, this is potentially the greatest present research frontier in many such cases – an explanation does not match a known rational process, which suggests that there must exist some unknown rational process

Foundations of Institutions

- Stinchcombe 1990: “What we want of our institutions of reason is a proper balance between efficient formal approximations that can have a reliable social effect, and substantive good sense to know their limits and to improve them.”
- North 1990a, 1990b: Institutions are “the rules of the game,” “consist of informal constraints and formal rules and of their enforcement characteristics.”
 - Per North – Institutions exist to reduce transaction costs, and the effectiveness of an institution (or series of institutions) can be broadly measured by evaluating its resultant reduction of transaction costs
 - However, also per North 1990b – some institutions seek to raise transaction costs (especially in third world countries)
 - Cites North 1981 – two reasons for institutions producing lesser property rights. First, may pander to certain powerful groups who may otherwise support an alternative ruler/regime. Second, may seek to gain tax revenue (which could be decreased through stronger property rights)
 - North 1990b: “a basic function of institutions is to provide stability and continuity by dampening the effects of relative price changes. It is institutional stability that makes possible complex exchange across space and time.”

Legislative Principal/Agents

- Cartel theory: parties are weak but legislators are strong; parties effectively cannot control their members (at least in US congress) and so instead must resort to influence

and responsiveness

- Legislators face an inherent incentive to prioritize their own voters, but this can be counterproductive for their party – subsequently, a foundational tension exists between legislators and their party leaders about whether to vote in line or pursue individual goals:
 - Diermeier & Vlaicu 2011: collective action problem where legislator can extract personal rents at the expense of party unity
 - Jones & Hwang 2005: Cartel theory seems to occur in Argentina
 - Kats & Mair 1995: Cartel theory; mass party is a single point in party development and cartels create a near-total overlap between the party and the state
 - Crisp et al 2004: Legislators decide whether to focus on local or national issues
 - Carey & Shugart 1995: When voters decide to prioritize personal versus party reputation; how this might change across voting systems (big note here: closed list is hard-for-party)
 - Cox 1987: How this power cessation to the party occurred (by means of solving an information problem)
- Legislators have multiple principals to whom they are agents (Carey 2009) – the more agents there are, and the more authority they have, and the more their goals conflict, the less effective we should expect legislative outcomes to be.
 - Tsebelis 1999: the more veto players, the less effective we should expect the legislature to be – laws passed will be less significant
- For legislatures as principals, see Huber & Shipan 2002
- Huber & Shipan 2002: legislative capacity – the costs that legislators face to drafting detailed legislation (opportunity, time, etc.)

Legislative Accountability & Elections

- Cox 1997: Elections are market activities with a balanced supply and demand of candidates ($M+1$ rule) BUT can be broken by specifically ethnic or geographic parties, etc. (like SNP)
 - Gibbard-Satterthwaite impossibility: either dictatorship, non-universality, not-strategy-proof, or indecisive
 - Arrow impossibility: either dictatorship, or IIA, or non-pareto
- Cox 1997: Three fundamental translations: social cleavages into partisan preferences, partisan preferences into votes, votes into seats
- Lijphart 1999: central bank dependency as a metric of federal vs. unitary systems

Majoritarian vs. Proportionalism

- Boix 1999: ruling parties can use the transition between majoritarianism and PR to maintain some exclusivity (even if possibly conceding contestation)
- Can tie to Ziblatt 2017 – do the elites maintain meaningful political influence as democratization occurs? This is potentially more feasible under proportionalism than majoritarianism
- Huber & Shipan 2002: Autonomy can also be largely influenced by whether or not the governing body has a majority versus a proportional lead: in the case of a majority, where ongoing conflict may be lessened (lesser need to involve the opposition), we can expect to see greater discretion to bureaucrats as they have fewer competing agents and are more trusted by the ruling government
- Lijphart 1999: Core breakdown of majoritarian as government *by* the people but proportionalism as government *for* the people. Characterizes democracies along an executive-parties dimension and a federal-unitary dimension
- Proportionalism protects minorities:
 - Lijphart 1999: consensus democracy effective when national cleavages are clear, by lowering the stakes of winning office and protecting minorities
 - Lewis 1965: “to exclude the losing groups from participation in decision-making clearly violates the primary meaning of democracy.”

Note: Westminster as a majoritarian model with power centralized in a cabinet / PM

Authoritarian Politics

- Repression is costly (Dahl 1972) and accordingly regimes without significant resources may just be more likely to tolerate an active opposition; conversely, if the state is highly endowed, this can raise the stakes of holding office and become a broader issue [cite this specifically? Svolik 2012?](#)
 - Broad-scale oppression does not happen in polyarchies (Dahl 1972) – low barriers to contestation protect inclusivity for marginalized groups and preemptively dissuades additional violence by the state
- Broadly characterized by either traditional or (especially) charismatic leadership a la Weber’s tripartite approach to authority

Institutional Endogeneity

- Electoral institutions are created by political actors with incentives to maximize their chances of achieving, holding, and executing power (Boix 1999, Lijphart 1991 is a bit softer)

- The choice of electoral institutions tangibly impacts policy outcomes – very similar to above point, with Cox’s applied translations (social cleavages → partisan preferences → votes → seats) – see Cox 1997
- An abundance of resources makes holding power more valuable; Dahl 1972: those with the means to do so will attempt to bend political systems in their favor, but the distribution of those means itself is endogenous. (Also tied to inequality, which can arise in more developed economies)
- Huber & Shipman 2002: bureaucratic institutions chosen based on the trust of the ruling party in bureaucrats to implement their ideal policies
- Huntington 1968: while economic and social development may occur endogenously, political institutionalization requires applied efforts and organization
- Levy 2006: somewhat endogenous? Transition of institutional goals
- Miller 1990: managers look for modes of inducing voluntary cooperation within the Leviathan, particularly given the difficulty of establishing logically consistent incentive structures to do so

Presidential vs Parliamentary

Bureaucracy

- Huber & Shipman 2002 – all of deliberate discretion. Discretion to bureaucratic agencies is a function of the trust the ruling party has in its bureaucratic agents and the level of conflict/competition in place from other parties. Also note: “Wise and salutary neglect” as a quote from Edmund Burke 1775
- Informational asymmetry forms the basis of much of this discretion (Huber & Shipman 2002) – bureaucrats often have better information / more expertise than legislators, but also may have misaligned incentives

State Capacity

- General model of development in Huntington 1968
- Ziblatt 2017 – capacity to involve the elites while still expanding the franchise?
- Ostrom 1990 – is there enough social capital to make endogenous institutions effective? (Very much in line with Putnam here as well)
- Huber & Shipman 2002 – state capacity ultimately impacts how politicians will organize bureaucratic orders. Also, state capacity may be modeled as the costs that the state faces to governing (maybe this can be better viewed as efficiency?)
- Huntington 1968 (the whole thing, pretty much)

- Another point of state capacity: the political institutions must have the capacity to handle the involvement of all those who are part of the political sphere. If there is not sufficient institutional / state capacity to handle this, we should expect to see extrainstitutional (and often violent) alternatives
- Levy 2006: state capacity hasn't decreased, it's just shifted to alternative activities
- Iversen & Soskice 2019: state capacity facilitates efficient markets (and state capacity is driven by broad participation of relevant actors)
- Kalyvas 2006: indiscriminate violence more likely when control over a region is minimal
- Hardin 1990: Gunman theory of law – enforcement purely by means of fear / violence is unachievable and inadequate

Other assorted factors (and where to find them)

- Trust: Dahl 1972, mechanized through commitment devices by A&R, N&W, and within authoritarian states by Gandhi & Przeworski 2007. Kalyvas 2006: indiscriminate violence destroys trust between regime and supporters and is subsequently counterproductive